

GS Conditional Structures

WHAT THIS STRUCTURE MEANS

Conditional structures let you argue about what could happen, what would have happened, or what must be true if certain conditions are met. At ILR 3, conditionals are not just grammar — they are a reasoning tool. When you use a conditional, you are projecting consequences, testing assumptions, and showing your listener that you understand the relationship between cause and outcome. A strong conditional move takes your argument beyond what is — into what follows.

WHAT TO TRY

- Use real conditionals (if... then...) to project likely consequences of a policy or action
- Use hypothetical conditionals (if... would...) to test alternative scenarios or challenge assumptions
- Use mixed conditionals to connect past conditions to present outcomes
- Stack conditionals to show a chain of consequences: if A, then B; if B, then C
- Use negative conditionals to identify what fails without a key condition: without X, Y cannot occur

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "If this policy were implemented without safeguards, the most likely outcome would be..."
- "Even if we accept that premise, it does not follow that..."
- "If the goal is X, then the more effective approach would be..."
- "Without a clear framework, any attempt to regulate this would risk..."
- "Assuming conditions remain constant, we would expect to see..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

Topic: Should cities invest in public transit or road expansion?

*"If cities continue to prioritize road expansion, the evidence suggests congestion will increase rather than decrease — more roads **tend to generate** more traffic. If the goal is genuine mobility, then investment in integrated transit **would likely** produce better outcomes over time. Even if we assume that most residents currently prefer driving, that preference **could shift** if reliable alternatives existed. Without a long-term **commitment** to transit infrastructure, cities **would remain** dependent on a system that **may not** scale sustainably."*

Bold phrases mark active conditional moves — projecting outcomes, testing assumptions, and tracing chains of consequence.